interview in 2017, ‘I’ll never forget the way he [Modi] found solutions for companies that were looking for a home.’

On 7 October, Ratan announced that the new plant would be set up in Sanand, Gujarat. Tata Motors revealed that the first of the cars would roll out in March 2009 with an estimated production of 2.5 lakh cars per annum. There was a sense of renewed hope. But the task ahead was gargantuan. The team at Tata Motors went back to their drawing boards to strategize and evolve a foolproof plan to implement their goal.

A journey that began five years ago saw signs of becoming a reality. From its conception to production and its commercial launch, the Nano project was plagued with enormous challenges. But it was Ratan’s doggedness that saw it through. A car that was once deemed impossible by the world was on the cusp of becoming a reality.

Unveiling the Dream

Ratan had planned to unveil the Nano at the 2008 Auto Expo in Delhi, and he stopped short of virtually nothing to accomplish this. He had seven cars produced at Tata Motors’ Engineering Research Centre in Pune under an impregnable veil of secrecy. And, as planned, on 10 January 2008, he introduced his ‘Nano’ to the world.

And he did it in an unusual way. At exactly 11.30 a.m., with the theme from Stanley Kubrick’s *2001: A Space Odyssey* playing in the background, he drove a white Nano onto the stage before a mesmerized audience. The two anchors of his project—Kant and Wagh—joined him onstage.

The Nano on display was a sleek, compact car with a two-cylinder aluminium 624cc engine and was available in three variants. It met all of India’s vehicle emissions, regulatory and safety requirements.

Now Ratan came to the big question—the price. If the movie-style introduction of the car was dramatic, the announcement of the price was no less. The price of commodities had gone up since he had announced the indicative cost some five years ago. Would he be able to sell the car at Rs 1 lakh? He drew oohs and aahs from an astonished audience when he declared: ‘I would like to announce today that the standard car will, in fact, have a dealer price of one lakh only. That is because a promise is a promise.’